
POLISH EARLY MUSIC 5

MIKOŁAJ ZIELEŃSKI

fl. 1604–1611

Vox in Rama

Communio in festo SS. Innocentium



for four voices

CRITICAL EDITION

from Communioness totius anni (Venice, 1611)

Tenor from the print; Cantus, Altus and Bassus from modern editions

edited by Mikołaj Derduń

First edition · 2026

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POLISH EARLY MUSIC 5. Mikołaj Zieleński, *Vox in Rama*. First edition, 2026. Edited by Mikołaj Derduń.

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Source files, corrections and later editions: <https://github.com/mderdun/pol-ren/editions/vox-in-rama>.

Set in Junicode; music engraved with LilyPond and Gregorio.

INTRODUCTION

VOX IN RAMA is the communion of the Mass of the Holy Innocents, 28 December. Mikołaj Zielenksi set it for four voices and organ, and it was printed in Venice in 1611 as no. 36 of his *Communiones totius anni* ('Communions for the whole year'). The *Communiones* were issued together with his *Offertoria totius anni* ('Offertories for the whole year') as a single publication with continuous signatures. Between them the two books hold all 113 of Zielenksi's known works.

Little is known about the composer. The title pages call him 'Polonus' ('a Pole') and 'organarius et capellae magister' ('organist and chapel master') to Wojciech Baranowski, archbishop of Gniezno and primate of Poland from 1608 until his death in 1615. Documents gathered by Polish scholars add that he came from Warka and married Anna Feterówna. In 1604 Baranowski, then bishop of Płock, gave him land at Gromin near Pułtusk. He appeared in court at Łowicz, the primate's seat, at the turn of February and March and again in April 1611. His dates of birth and death are unknown, and the '1550–1615' printed in library catalogues and on modern scores is a convention, not a documented span. Szymon Starowolski wrote in 1625 that Zielenksi had studied in Rome. No document confirms it. The dedication of the 1611 books is dated 'Venetijs Kalend. Martij' ('at Venice, on the Kalends of March'), on a day when the Łowicz records place him in Poland, so it says nothing about where he was.

The dedication does explain why the books were made. Baranowski, it says, had restored order in his dioceses and ordered that 'this proper singing of the offertories and communions, each in its place and season' be exactly observed (*hanc ipsam certam ac propriam Offertoriorum, ac Communiorum suis locis et temporibus decantationem exactè obseruari imperasti*). He commissioned the work and paid for the printing. Bound with the parts is a calendar, the *Registrum*, that assigns an offertory and a communion to each feast. Agnieszka Leszczyńska calls it unprecedented in prints of polyphony. It lists *Vox in Rama* for the Innocents and again for their octave on 4 January. Zielenksi also claims a first. These, he writes, are offertories and communions 'composed for the first time by a Pole in the new manner' (*primum à Polono nouo modo concinnata*).

The *Communiones* are ordered by scoring, not by the calendar. Pieces for one voice and organ come first, then pieces for two and three voices with instruments, then the pieces for four, five and six voices. *Vox in Rama* is the fourth of eleven four-voice pieces. A rubric in the index governs all the pieces from four voices up: those that go plainly (*simpliciter*) are to be sung with the organ and played on instruments; those written with ornaments (*cum resolutione*) are sung by the singers with the organ played softly. *Vox in Rama* is one of the plain pieces. The catalogue of Kurtzman and Schnoebelen, made from the Wrocław and Kraków books, records a further rubric for it: 'Soli debent cantare cum Organo' ('they are to sing alone with the organ').

The text. The communion takes Matthew 2:18, where the evangelist quotes Jeremiah 31:15 after the slaughter of the children of Bethlehem. The Missal of 1570 gives it as 'Vox in Rama audita est, ploratus & ululatus: Rachel plorans filios suos: & noluit consolari, quia non sunt'. This is the Vulgate text of Matthew without *multus*, which there reads 'ploratus, et ululatus multus' ('weeping and great wailing'). Jeremiah's own Vulgate wording is different: 'Vox in excelso audita est lamentationis, luctus, et fletus Rachel plorantis filios suos' ('a voice was heard on high, of lamentation, of mourning and of weeping, of Rachel weeping for her children'). The feast was kept as a day of mourning inside Christmastide. The general rubrics of the same Missal prescribe violet vestments for the Innocents unless the day falls on a Sunday.

The music. The setting is 45 breves long and follows the text phrase by phrase. Each voice states 'Vox in Rama' two or three times in staggered entries, often adding a further 'in Rama', and the long melismas fall on the stressed 'Ra'. 'Audita est' is set almost syllabically. The chromatic writing is kept for 'ploratus et ululatus'. In bar 15 the Cantus falls c''–b'–bb', and the bb' sounds over the Altus f# and the Tenor d', an augmented triad on 'ululatus'. In bar 18 the Cantus has g''–f#''–f''. 'Rachel plorans' and 'filios suos' are short imitative points. 'Et noluit consolari' comes four times in the Altus and Tenor and three times in the Cantus and Bassus. 'Quia non sunt' is set twice, the second time over a Bassus d held for two breves, and the piece closes on a chord of A with a major third.

The text had been set often as a motet, by Clemens non Papa for four voices, for example, and by Giaches de Wert for five (printed 1581). Zieleński wrote it as the proper of the day: short, close to the words, and with the organ beneath the voices.

SOURCES

The print. *Communiones totius anni quibus in solennioribus festis Sancta Romana Ecclesia uti consuevit ad cantum Organi, per Vnam, Duas, Tres, Quatuor, Quinque, & Sex voces ...* Venetiis, Apud Iacobum Vincentium. MDCXI (RISM A/I Z 200, issued with Z 199). Quarto partbooks and a folio *Partitura pro organo*. The only complete set came from the church of St Bernardine in Wrocław and was in the city library until 1942. Half of it was lost in the war. What survives:

PL-WRu Wrocław, Biblioteka Uniwersytecka: Cantus primi chori, Tenor primi chori, Altus secundi chori, Tenor secundi chori.

PL-Kc Kraków, Biblioteka Książąt Czartoryskich: *Partitura pro organo*. According to the Musicare database it gives some pieces in full score.

PL-Kj Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska: Cantus only.

The four voices of no. 36 were printed in the books of the first choir. The Tenor primi chori survives and is the source of this edition's Tenor. The Cantus primi chori also survives and should hold the Cantus, but its facsimile was not available. The Altus and Bassus primi chori are lost. Before the war Zdzisław Jachimecki and Maria Szczepańska transcribed the complete set, and every later edition rests on their copies.

Ⓣ Tenor primi chori, no. 36: 'A 4. In festo Sanctorum Innocentium. 36 TENOR' ('For 4. On the feast of the Holy Innocents. 36 Tenor'). Six staves; C2 clef, sign cut-C; text placed under the notes, with *ij* for repeated words. Facsimile in *Monumenta Musicae in Polonia*, ser. D, vol. 12, ed. Jerzy Morawski (Kraków: PWM, 1983), read in a scan of the Chicago Public Library copy. *Base text for the Tenor*.

Ⓝ *Vox in Rama*, notAmos Performing Editions, full score 100881 (PDF, 2020; CPDL). Four voices and a keyboard reduction. Final E, one-sharp signature, note values halved, barred in a mixture of 3/2 and 2/2.

Ⓜ *Vox in Rama*, ed. Paul R. Marchesano (Finale PDF, 2009, and MusicXML, 2017; CPDL). Final F, four-flat signature, note values halved, barred in 4/4. *Base text for Cantus, Altus and Bassus*.

Ⓝ and Ⓜ agree in every note, rest and accidental. Ⓜ lies a semitone above Ⓝ, and the two are barred differently. Their underlay differs in two places (bars 5–6 and 38–39). Both name the 1611 print as their source, but neither can have been made from the partbooks alone, since the Altus and Bassus are lost. Two editions that agree note for note across 45 breves, down to accidentals that Ⓣ does not print, must share a parent: WDMP 12, Malinowski, or the *Partitura* in facsimile. Their agreement therefore counts as one witness, not two. Ⓜ was chosen as base text because it exists as encoded data.

Editions not seen. Adolf Chybiński and Bronisław Rutkowski edited *Vox in Rama* as Wydawnictwo Dawnej Muzyki Polskiej 12 (Warsaw: TWMP, 1933; reissued by PWM in 1964, 1971 and 1980) 'wg druku z r. 1611' ('from the print of 1611'), while the print was still complete. The library catalogue gives its scoring as '2 soprani, mezzosoprano e tenore [con organo]' ('2 sopranos, mezzo-soprano and tenor [with organ]'), which matches the ranges at the printed pitch. Władysław Malinowski's *Opera omnia* in *Monumenta Musicae in Polonia*, ser. A (1966–91), has the communions in vols. 4–5. The facsimiles of the Cantus primi chori (MMP D/11) and the *Partitura* (MMP D/15) have not been seen.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Status of the text. The Tenor is edited from the 1611 print. The other three voices come from (M), a modern edition at least two steps removed from the print. (T) shows how far such an edition can be trusted. Its notes and rhythms agree with (M) everywhere, once (M)'s transposition and halved values are undone. Its accidentals do not: of the thirteen chromatic notes in (M)'s Tenor, eight are printed in (T), four are sharps supplied by the parent edition, and one, the *eb'* in bar 15, is an *eb'* in the print. Readers should assume that the accidentals of the Cantus, Altus and Bassus include editorial ones in about the same proportion. One reading of (M) is emended, in the Altus at bars 17–18 (see the notes).

Pitch, values and barring. As in (T). The Tenor's C2 clef puts the piece on A with no signature, a fourth above (N) and a major third above (M). Note values are those of (T), twice those of (N) and (M). The sign cut-C is (T)'s; the edition assumes it stood in every voice. A bar is one breve, the tactus. Bar lines are drawn between the staves only (*Mensurstriche*). A note that runs across a bar line keeps its single value; the edition adds no ties. The incipit before the Tenor gives the clef, sign and first note of (T); the clefs of the other voices are not known, and they have no incipit. The range of each voice is shown at the head of its staff. The final notes are longae, as in (T).

Voices and clefs. At the printed pitch the ranges are Cantus *g'–a''*, Altus *d'–f''* (after the emendation in bars 17–18), Tenor *g–a'* and Bassus *A–c'*. With a Tenor in C2 they point to a high set of clefs, perhaps G2, G2 or C1, C2, F3, which is what the WDMP scoring '2 soprani, mezzosoprano e tenore' ('2 sopranos, mezzo-soprano and tenor') describes. Cantus and Altus are a pair of equal voices: they enter on the same *e''*, share a range and cross often. The Cantus cannot belong an octave lower. There it would lie below the Altus at nine in ten note onsets and below the Tenor at more than half of them, while at the printed octave it never goes below the Tenor. The Cantus and Altus are printed in the treble clef, the Tenor in the octave treble clef, the Bassus in the bass clef.

Sounding pitch. High clefs were a way of writing, not a pitch to be sung. Adriano Banchieri's *Cartella* (Venice, 1601; 2nd edn 1610, pp. 13–15) states the rule that pieces in the G clef are sung a fourth lower when they have a flat and a fifth lower when they have none: 'quando sono per b. molle si trasportano ... una Quarta bassa, & quando sono per b. quadro, si trasportano similmente una Quinta bassa' ('when they are in *b molle* they are transposed ... a fourth lower, and when they are in *b quadro* they are likewise transposed a fifth lower'). His written-out example of the fifth-lower case has its Tenor in C2, the clef of (T). Silverio Picerli gives the same rule in 1631. Both are quoted, with Banchieri's example, by Andrew Johnstone (2006). *Vox in Rama* has no signature, so by this rule it sounded a fifth lower, ending on D: Cantus *c'–d''*, Altus *g–bb'*, Tenor *c–d'*, Bassus *D–f*, an ordinary four-part choir. The organ basses that Palestrina's publishers printed for his high-clef works follow the same rule, a fifth lower without a flat and a fourth lower with one. Praetorius (1619) allows a fourth for some modes, and later Italian practice moved towards the fourth (Doni, 1640; Pasquini, 1695). The CPDL editions take it down a fourth, to E. A fourth down cannot be written in the notation of 1611 without a one-sharp signature, while a fifth down gives D with one flat, an ordinary notation of the time. The *Partitura* may settle the question, since organ parts sometimes printed the transposition. This edition prints the written pitch; the performance edition is a fifth lower.

Accidentals. In the Tenor, accidentals before notes are those of (T), and accidentals above the staff are editorial. In the other voices every accidental is (M)'s and stands before the note, whether the print had it or not. As in the sources of the period, a sign applies only to the note it stands against. A *b* after a *bb* in the same bar is *bb* and carries no sign.

Ligatures and coloration. The three ligatures of (T), all *cum opposita proprietate*, are shown by brackets above the notes. In the second (bar 17) the second note is black; corner brackets mark it.

Underlay. (T) places its text under the notes but loosely, and writes *ij* where words repeat. Its words fall where (M)'s do. (M)'s underlay was then checked syllable by syllable against the rules of this series. It keeps every firm rule: no new syllable on a fusa or a dot, a syllable on the first note after every rest, no word divided by a rest, no elision. It

departs from the sixteenth-century theorists in two ways, and in both the print's Tenor does the same, so the edition follows the print. First, a semiminim after a dotted minim takes a syllable ('fi-li-os', 'nó-lu-it'), which Zarlino forbids but which is ordinary by 1611. Second, every voice sets the unstressed 'con-' of 'consolari' to a melisma of five to seven notes; (T)'s spacing, 'con ... sola-', shows the same. In bars 5–6 of the Altus (N)'s underlay is preferred, for the reason given in the notes.

Text. Spelling follows modern Latin use (*et* for the print's ampersand, *ululatus* for (T)'s *vlulatus*). Punctuation follows the Missal. The first word is capitalised; repeated 'vox' is not.



TEXT AND TRANSLATION

Vox in Rama audita est,
ploratus et ululatus:
Rachel plorans filios suos,
et noluit consolari,
quia non sunt.

*A voice was heard in Rama,
weeping and wailing:
Rachel weeping for her children,
and she would not be comforted,
because they are not.*

Matthew 2:18, after Jeremiah 31:15. Text of the communion for the feast of the Holy Innocents in the *Missale Romanum* (Venice, 1570).

A 4. In festo Sanctorum Innocentium.

Vox in Rama

Communio in festo SS. Innocentium

MIKOŁAJ ZIELEŃSKI

CANTUS

ALTUS

TENOR

BASSUS

C.

A.

T.

B.

Vox in Ra - ma, vox in Ra - ma, in

Vox in Ra - ma, in Ra -

Vox in Ra - ma,

Ra - - ma, vox in Ra - ma, in Ra -

- ma, vox in Ra - ma, in Ra -

in Ra - - - ma, vox in Ra - ma, in Ra -

Vox in Ra - ma, vox in Ra - -

ma au - di - ta est, au - di - ta est, plo - ra - tus et u - lu - la -

ma au - di - ta est, au - di - ta est, plo - ra - tus et u - lu - la -

ma au - di - ta est, plo - ra - tus et u -

ma au - di - ta est,

16

C. tus, plo - ra - tus et u - lu - la - tus,

A. - - - tus, plo - ra - tus et u - lu - la - -

T. lu - la - - tus, Ra - chel plo - rans,

B. plo - ra - tus et u - lu - la - tus, Ra -

21

C. Ra - chel plo - rans, Ra - chel plo - rans, fi -

A. - tus, Ra - chel plo - rans, Ra - chel plo - rans, fi -

T. Ra - chel plo - rans, Ra - chel plo - rans, fi -

B. - chel plo - - rans, Ra - chel plo - rans, fi -

25

C. - li - os su - os, fi - li - os su - - os,

A. - li - os su - os, fi - li - os su - - os, et no - lu -

T. - li - os su - os, fi - li - os su - - os, et no - lu -

B. - li - os su - os, fi - li - os su - - os,

29

C. et no - lu - it con - so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con -

A. it con - so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con - so - la - ri,

T. it con - so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con - so - la -

B. et no - lu - it con - so - la - ri, et no - lu -

35

C. - so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con so - la -

A. et no - lu - it con so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con so - la -

T. ri, et no - lu - it con so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con so -

B. it con - so - la - ri, et no - lu - it con so - la -

40

C. ri, qui - a non sunt, qui - a non sunt.

A. ri, qui - a non sunt, qui - a non sunt.

T. la - ri, qui - a non sunt, qui - a non sunt.

B. ri, qui - a non sunt, qui - a non sunt.



CRITICAL NOTES

Bar numbers refer to this edition, one breve to the bar. Pitches are given at this edition's pitch, with c' as middle C. Voices: C, A, T, B. Readings of (N) and (M) are quoted at this pitch.

BAR	VOICE	NOTE
5–6	A	Underlay. (M) sets 'Ra-ma' on c'' – b' and then a melisma of eight notes on ' ma '. (N) sets 'Ra-ma, in Ra-ma': 'in' on a' (bar 5), 'Ra-' on $g\sharp'$, ' ma ' on a' (bar 6). (N) is followed. Its melisma falls on the stressed syllable, and the Altus then says 'vox in Rama, in Rama' as the Cantus (bars 4–7) and Tenor (bars 3–9) do.
8	T	Fusae $g\sharp'$ $f\sharp'$: (T) without sharps; the minim $g\sharp'$ that follows has its sharp in (T). (N) and (M) sharpen all three.
15	T	e' – d' in ligature, e' without flat in (T). (N) and (M) have eb' . With $e\sharp'$ the Tenor sounds a sixth below c'' and then a fifth below b' ; with eb' it forms a minor 6/3 and then the augmented triad eb' – g' – b' . The flat is not in the print, and the counterpoint argues against it. It may come from the <i>Partitura</i> or from the parent edition. The real chromatic moment comes two minims later, when the Cantus bb' meets the Altus $f\sharp'$ over the Tenor d' .
17–18	A	Emended. (N) and (M) have a – c' – d' – e' an octave lower, the last four notes of the melisma on ' tus '. They take the Altus to a , a fourth below any other note in the part, and then make it leap e' – e'' to 'ploratus'. In the high clefs of this piece an Altus would hardly go below d' . Raised an octave, the line runs a' – c'' – d'' – e'' into the repeated e'' of 'ploratus', crosses no other voice, and makes no parallels. The Altus partbook is lost; the <i>Partitura</i> should settle it.
17	T	b – a in ligature, the second note black. In imperfect time a black semibreve followed by short notes is worth a dotted minim, which is the value (N) and (M) give it.
25, 31	T	The figure $c\sharp'$ – b – c' – d' at the cadence: (T) prints the sharp on the fusa and not on the minim. The minim's sharp is editorial. (N) and (M) have it before the note.
38–39	T	Underlay. (M): 'et no-lu-it (melisma) con- (melisma) so-la-ri'. (N): 'no-lu-it, no-lu-it con-so-la-ri', filling the melisma with another 'noluit'. (T) has '& no-' at the end of its fifth staff and 'luit conso la ri' at the start of the sixth, one statement only, so (N)'s extra 'noluit' is not in the print. (M) is kept: its long 'con-' falls with the long 'con-' of the Cantus and Altus.
42	C	e'' on the second minim against the Bassus f , both newly struck: a passing semiminim on the beat. (N) and (M) agree.
45		(T) ends on a longa a' , followed by the final bar line. (N) and (M) give breves. The other voices are given longae to match.

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